The Great Society

President Lyndon B. Johnson · commencement address · University of Michigan · May 22, 1964

Source: Lyndon B. Johnson, Remarks at the University of Michigan (May 22, 1964), text via The American Presidency Project, UC Santa Barbara. Public domain.

Johnson used this Michigan commencement address to roll out the name for his domestic program. Within the next two years Congress would pass an extraordinary burst of legislation: the Civil Rights Act of 1964, the Voting Rights Act of 1965, Medicare and Medicaid, the Elementary and Secondary Education Act, Head Start, the War on Poverty, the Immigration Act of 1965, and federal housing programs. The Great Society was both the high-water mark of mid-century American liberalism and a target of conservative backlash that shaped politics for the next 50+ years.

Connect: The Great Society expanded federal power much like FDR's New Deal (Class 45). Compare their targets: what problems did each try to solve?

Key Passages

The vision

> The Great Society rests on abundance and liberty for all. It demands an end to poverty and racial injustice, to which we are totally committed in our time. But that is just the beginning. The Great Society is a place where every child can find knowledge to enrich his mind and to enlarge his talents. … But most of all, the Great Society is not a safe harbor, a resting place, a final objective, a finished work. It is a challenge constantly renewed

Creative federalism

> The solution to these problems does not rest on a massive program in Washington, nor can it rely solely on the strained resources of local authority. They require us to create new concepts of cooperation, a creative federalism, between the National Capital and the leaders of local communities.

On the choice

> So, will you join in the battle to give every citizen the full equality which God enjoins and the law requires, whatever his belief, or race, or the color of his skin? Will you join in the battle to give every citizen an escape from the crushing weight of poverty? … Will you join in the battle to build the Great Society, to prove that our material progress is only the foundation on which we will build a richer life of mind and spirit?

HIPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	Prosperity of the 1960s alongside poverty and racial injustice; Johnson took office after JFK's assassination and was running for election in 1964.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	University of Michigan graduates and, through the press, the American public.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	Lyndon Johnson, a Democrat and New Deal-era politician who believed government could end poverty and expand opportunity.
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. Contextualization (DBQ/LEQ, 1 pt): Place the Great Society in the broader trajectory of 20th-century federal expansion (Progressive Era → New Deal → Great Society).
2. Identify TWO specific Great Society programs and what each was designed to do.
3. How did the Vietnam War complicate the Great Society's funding and political support?

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> At the University of Michigan, Johnson laid out his vision of a "Great Society" that would end poverty and racial injustice and renew American cities, countryside, and classrooms — the framework for his domestic reform agenda.

The challenge of the next half century

The purpose of protecting the life of our Nation and preserving the liberty of our citizens is to pursue the happiness of our people. Our success in that pursuit is the test of our success as a Nation. For a century we labored to settle and to subdue a continent. For half a century we called upon unbounded invention and untiring industry to create an order of plenty for all of our people. The challenge of the next half century is whether we have the wisdom to use that wealth to enrich and elevate our national life, and to advance the quality of our American civilization.

The vision

Your imagination, your initiative, and your indignation will determine whether we build a society where progress is the servant of our needs, or a society where old values and new visions are buried under unbridled growth. For in your time we have the opportunity to move not only toward the rich society and the powerful society, but upward to the Great Society. The Great Society rests on abundance and liberty for all. It demands an end to poverty and racial injustice, to which we are totally committed in our time. But that is just the beginning. The Great Society is a place where every child can find knowledge to enrich his mind and to enlarge his talents. It is a place where leisure is a welcome chance to build and reflect, not a feared cause of boredom and restlessness. It is a place where the city of man serves not only the needs of the body and the demands of commerce but the desire for beauty and the hunger for community. It is a place where man can renew contact with nature. It is a place which honors creation for its own sake and for what it adds to the understanding of the race. It is a place where men are more concerned with the quality of their goals than the quantity of their goods. But most of all, the Great Society is not a safe harbor, a resting place, a final objective, a finished work. It is a challenge constantly renewed, beckoning us toward a destiny where the meaning of our lives matches the marvelous products of our labor.

Three places to begin

So I want to talk to you today about three places where we begin to build the Great Society—in our cities, in our countryside, and in our classrooms.

[. . .]

The catalog of ills is long: there is the decay of the centers and the despoiling of the suburbs. There is not enough housing for our people or transportation for our traffic. Open land is vanishing and old landmarks are violated. Worst of all expansion is eroding the precious and time honored values of community with neighbors and communion with nature. The loss of these values breeds loneliness and boredom and indifference.

[. . .]

A second place where we begin to build the Great Society is in our countryside. We have always prided ourselves on being not only America the strong and America the free, but America the beautiful. Today that beauty is in danger. The water we drink, the food we eat, the very air that we breathe, are threatened with pollution. Our parks are overcrowded, our seashores overburdened. Green fields and dense forests are disappearing.

[. . .]

A third place to build the Great Society is in the classrooms of America. There your children's lives will be shaped. Our society will not be great until every young mind is set free to scan the farthest reaches of thought and imagination. We are still far from that goal. . . . Poverty must not be a bar to learning, and learning must offer an escape from poverty.

[. . .]

Creative federalism

The solution to these problems does not rest on a massive program in Washington, nor can it rely solely on the strained resources of local authority. They require us to create new concepts of cooperation, a creative federalism, between the National Capital and the leaders of local communities.

[. . .]

On the choice

For better or for worse, your generation has been appointed by history to deal with those problems and to lead America toward a new age. You have the chance never before afforded to any people in any age. You can help build a society where the demands of morality, and the needs of the spirit, can be realized in the life of the Nation.

So, will you join in the battle to give every citizen the full equality which God enjoins and the law requires, whatever his belief, or race, or the color of his skin? Will you join in the battle to give every citizen an escape from the crushing weight of poverty? Will you join in the battle to make it possible for all nations to live in enduring peace—as neighbors and not as mortal enemies ? Will you join in the battle to build the Great Society, to prove that our material progress is only the foundation on which we will build a richer life of mind and spirit?

Words to know

subdue — bring under control; tame

indignation — anger at injustice

unbridled — uncontrolled; without limits

abundance — great plenty of wealth and goods

despoiling — ruining or stripping of beauty

creative federalism — a new partnership where national and local governments work together on problems

enjoins — commands; requires